

EZRA VI.

the castle that is in the province of Media, a roll, and therein was thus written: A record.^a

3 ¶ In the first year of king Cyrus, king Cyrus gave an order concerning the house of God at Jerusalem, Let the house be built, the place where they used to offer sacrifices, and let its foundations be strongly laid: its height shall be sixty cubits, its breadth sixty cubits,

4 With three rows of heavy stones, and a row of new timber; and let the expenses be given out of the king's house.

5 And also let the golden and silver vessels of the house of God, which Nebuchadnezzar took away out of the temple which is in Jerusalem, and brought unto Babylon, be restored, and brought back unto the temple which is in Jerusalem, every one to its place, and let them be put in the house of God.

6 ¶ Now Thatnai, governor beyond the river, Shethar-bozenai, and your companions the Apharsachites, who are beyond the river, be ye far from there:

7 Let the work of this house of God alone; let the governor of the Jews and the elders of the Jews build this house of God on its site.

8 And by me is the order given what ye shall do to the elders of these Jews for the building of this house of God, that out of the king's property, arising out of the tax beyond the river, the expenses shall forthwith be given unto these men, that they be not hindered.

9 And what they have need of, both young bullocks, and rams, and lambs, for the burnt-offerings unto the God of heaven, wheat, salt, wine, and oil, according to the requirement of the priests who are at Jerusalem, shall be given unto them day by day, without fail:

10 That they may offer sacrifices of sweet savours unto the God of heaven, and pray for the life of the king and of his sons.

11 Also is by me the order given, that if any man should alter this command, timber shall be pulled down from his house, and being set up, he shall be hanged thereon; and his house shall be made a dunghill for this.

12 And may the God that causeth his name to dwell there cast down every king

and people that will stretch forth their hand to alter,^b to destroy this house of God which is in Jerusalem. I Darius have given the order: let it be done speedily.

13 ¶ Then did Thatnai the governor on this side of the river, Shethar-bozenai, and their companions, in accordance with what king Darius had sent, act in this manner speedily.

14 And the elders of the Jews built, and they prospered, through the prophesying of Haggai the prophet, and Zechariah the son of 'Iddo. And they built, and completed it, according to the order of the God of Israel, and according to the order of Cyrus, and Darius, and Artaxerxes^c the king of Persia.

15 And this house was finished on the third day of the month Adar, which was in the sixth year of the reign of king Darius.

16 Then celebrated the children of Israel, the priests, and the Levites, and the rest of the children of the exile, the dedication of this house of God with joy;

17 And they offered for the dedication of this house of God one hundred bullocks, two hundred rams, four hundred lambs; and for a sin-offering for all Israel, twelve he-goats, according to the number of the tribes of Israel.

18 And they stationed the priests in their orders, and the Levites in their divisions, for the service of God, which is in Jerusalem, as it is written in the book of Moses.

19 ¶ And the children of the exile prepared the passover-(sacrifice) on the fourteenth day of the first month.

20 For the priests and the Levites had purified themselves, as one man were all of them clean; and they slaughtered the passover-sacrifice for all the children of the exile, and for their brethren the priests, and for themselves.

21 And then did the children of Israel, who were returned out of the exile, and all such as had separated themselves unto them from the uncleanness of the nations of the earth, to seek the LORD the God of Israel, eat thereof.

22 And they celebrated the feast of unleavened bread seven days with joy; for the LORD had made them joyful, and had turned the heart of the king of Asshur toward them,

^a So First; *i. e.* the record bore this inscription. Others, "was written as a record."

^b Herseimer explains, "this decree."

^c Chald. *Artachshasth*, Artaxerxes Longimanus, the

second successor of Darius Hystaspis. Perhaps the king here named was Xerxes, as Longimanus became king about 55 years after this time; consequently the temple was completed by Zerubbabel before his accession.

to strengthen their hands in the work of the house of God, the God of Israel.

CHAPTER VII.

1 ¶ And after these things, in the reign of Artaxerxes the king of Persia, 'Ezra^a the son of Serayah, the son of 'Azaryah, the son of Chilkiah,

2 The son of Shallum, the son of Zadok, the son of Achiub,

3 The son of Amaryah, the son of 'Azaryah, the son of Merayoth,

4 The son of Zerachyah, the son of 'Uzzi, the son of Bukki,

5 'The son of Abishua', the son of Phinehas, the son of Elazar, the son of Aaron the chief priest:

6 This 'Ezra went up from Babylon; and he was a practised expounder^b in the law of Moses, which the LORD the God of Israel hath given; and the king gave him, according to the hand of the LORD his God upon him, all his request.

7 And there went up some of the children of Israel, and of the priests, and the Levites, and the singers, and the gate-keepers, and the temple-servants, unto Jerusalem, in the seventh year of king Artaxerxes.

8 And he came to Jerusalem in the fifth month, which was in the seventh year of the king.

9 For on the first day of the first month was the commencement of the expedition from Babylon, and on the first day of the fifth month came he to Jerusalem, according to the good hand of his God upon him.

10 For 'Ezra had directed his heart to inquire in the law of the LORD, and to do it, and to teach in Israel statutes and ordinances.

11 ¶ Now this is the copy of the letter which king Artaxerxes gave unto 'Ezra the priest, the expounder of the law, the expounder of the words of the commandments of the LORD, and of his statutes for Israel.

12 Artaxerxes, the king of kings, unto

'Ezra the priest, the expounder of the law of the God of heaven, the perfect, and so forth.

13 By me is the order given, that every one who is freely willing in my kingdom out of the people of Israel, and their priests and Levites, to go up to Jerusalem, may go up with thee;

14 Forasmuch as thou art sent on the part of the king, and of his seven counsellors, to make inquiry concerning Judah and Jerusalem, according to the law of thy God which is in thy hand;

15 And to carry the silver and gold, which the king and his counsellors have freely offered unto the God of Israel, whose habitation is in Jerusalem,

16 And all (freewill offerings of) silver and gold that thou canst find in all the province of Babylon, with the freewill offerings which the people and the priests offer willingly for the house of their God which is in Jerusalem.

17 Therefore mayest thou buy speedily with this money bullocks, rams, lambs, with their meat-offerings and their drink-offerings, and offer them upon the altar of the house of your God which is in Jerusalem.

18 And whatsoever shall seem good to thee, and to thy brethren, to do with the rest of the silver and the gold, that do according to the will of your God.

19 And the vessels which have been given unto thee for the service of the house of thy God, deliver thou before the God of Jerusalem.

20 And the remainder that will yet be needful for the house of thy God, which thou shalt have occasion to procure,^c procure out of the king's treasure-house.

21 And by me, me king Artaxerxes, is the order given unto all the treasurers who are beyond the river, that whatsoever 'Ezra the priest, the expounder of the law of the God of heaven, may demand of you, shall be done speedily,

22 Up to one hundred talents of silver,

^a According to Zunz's chronological tables, there elapsed 58 years between the finishing of the temple under Zerubbabel and Zechariah and their associates to the immigration of 'Ezra under *Arthachshasth*, as he is called here. But Rashi makes him identical with Darius—*Arthachshasth* being taken as a general appellation of the Persian kings; and others deem 'Ezra identical with Malachi.

^b Rashi. Lit. "scribe," but the word סופר *sopher*, though often meaning secretary or scribe, signifies also one learned in religion; the word frequently occurring in the Mishnah סופרים "the learned," or "scholars;" but it is also possible that 'Ezra was a state secretary to the Persian king, wherefore he was sent to Judah.

^c Lit. "to give," "to pay out."

and up to one hundred cors of wheat, and up to one hundred baths of wine, and up to one hundred baths of oil, and salt without prescribing it.

23 Whatsoever is ordered by the God of heaven shall be carefully done for the house of the God of heaven; for why should there be wrath against the kingdom of the king and his sons?

24 And to you make we it known, that on any of the priests and Levites, singers, gatekeepers, and temple-servants, or ministers of this house of God, no one shall be empowered to impose any tax, tribute, or toll.

25 And thou, 'Ezra, according to the wisdom of thy God which is in thy hand, appoint judges and magistrates, who are to judge all the people that are beyond the river, all such as know the laws of thy God; and make ye them known to those^a that know them not.

26 And if there be any one who will not execute the law of thy God, and the law of the king, let justice be speedily executed upon him, whether it be unto death or to banishment,^b or to a fine on goods, or to imprisonment.

27 ¶ Blessed be the LORD the God of our fathers, who hath put the like of this in the heart of the king, to glorify the house of the LORD which is in Jerusalem;

28 And who hath extended kindness unto me before the king and his counsellors, and before all the mighty princes of the king: and I strengthened myself according to the hand of the LORD my God upon me, and I gathered together out of Israel principal men to go up with me.

CHAPTER VIII.

1 ¶ Now these are the chiefs of their divisions, and this is the genealogy of those that went up with me, in the reign of king Artaxerxes, from Babylon.

2 Of the sons of Phinchas, Gershom; of the sons of Ithamar, Daniel; of the sons of David, Chattush;

3 Of the sons of Shechanyah, (who was) of the sons of Par'osh, Zechariah; and with

him were recorded by genealogy of males one hundred and fifty.

4 Of the sons of 'Pachath-moâb, Elyeho-'enai the son of 'Zerachyah, and with him were two hundred males.

5 Of the sons of Shechanyah, the son of Yachaziël, and with him were three hundred males.

6 And of the sons of 'Adin, 'Ebed the son of Jonathan, and with him were fifty males.

7 And of the sons of 'Elam, Jesha'yah the son of 'Athalyah, and with him were seventy males.

8 And of the sons of Shephatyah, Zebadyah the son of Michaël, and with him were eighty males.

9 Of the sons of Joâb, 'Obadiah the son of Jechiël, and with him were two hundred and eighteen males.

10 And of the sons of Shelomith, the son of Jossiptyah, and with him were one hundred and sixty males.

11 And of the sons of Bebai, Zechariah the son of Bebai, and with him were twenty and eight males.

12 And of the sons of 'Azgad, Jochanan the son of Hakkatan, and with him were one hundred and ten males.

13 And of the sons of Adonikam the last; and these are their names, Eliphelet, Je'ïël, and Shema'yah, and with them were sixty males.

14 And of the sons of Bigvai, 'Uthai, and Zabbur, and with them were seventy males.

15 ¶ And I gathered them together to the river that runneth into the Ahava, and we encamped there three days: and I looked about among the people, and the priests, but of the sons of Levi I found none there.

16 Then sent I for Eli'ezer, for Ariël, for Shema'yah, and for Elnathan, and for Jarib, and for Elnathan, and for Nathan, and for Zechariah, and for Meshullam, the head men; also for Joyarib, and for Elnathan, men of understanding.^c

17 And I sent them with a charge unto Iddo the chief at the place Cassiphia, and I laid the words in their mouth to speak unto Iddo, and to his brother,^d who were appoint-

^a Rashi explains this to refer to the judges. By this edict the Israelites were to be judged after the Jewish, not the Persian laws, and 'Ezra was to be the chief justice, but not the civil governor.

^b Rashi, "extermination."

^c Rashi; but Fürst, "teachers."

^d Rashi would translate this *Achie*, as a proper name, not "his brother."

ed^a at the place Cassiphia, that they should bring unto us ministers for the house of our God.

18 And they brought unto us according to the good hand of our God upon us a man of intelligence, of the sons of Machli, the son of Levi, the son of Israel, namely, Sherebyah, with his sons and his brothers, eighteen;

19 And Chashabayah, and with him Jeshayah of the sons of Merari, his brothers and their sons, twenty.

20 ¶ Also of the temple-servants, whom David and the princes had assigned for the service of the Levites two hundred and twenty temple-servants, all of whom were expressed by names.

21 Then did I proclaim a fast there, at the river Ahava, that we might afflict ourselves before our God, to request from him a prosperous journey^b for us, and for our little ones, and for all our substance.

22 For I was ashamed to ask of the king an army and horsemen to assist us against an enemy on the way; because we had spoken unto the king, saying, The hand of our God is upon all those that seek him for good; but his power and his wrath are against all those that forsake him.

23 So we fasted and besought our God for this, and he suffered himself to be entreated by us.

24 Then set I apart of the chiefs of the priests twelve persons, Sherebyah, Chashabayah, and with them ten of their brethren,

25 And I weighed out unto them the silver, and the gold, and the vessels, the offering for the house of our God, which the king, and his counsellors, and his princes, and all Israel there present, had offered.

26 And I weighed out into their hand of silver six hundred and fifty talents, and of silver vessels one hundred talents, of gold one hundred talents;

27 Also twenty cups of gold, of a thousand drachms; and two vessels of fine polished copper, valuable as gold.

28 And I said unto them, Ye are holy unto the LORD; and the vessels are holy; and the silver and the gold are a freewill

offering unto the LORD the God of your fathers.

29 Watch ye, and guard them, until ye weigh them out before the chiefs of the priests and the Levites, and the chiefs of the divisions of Israel, at Jerusalem, into the chambers of the house of the LORD.

30 And the priests and the Levites accepted what was weighed out of the silver, and the gold, and the vessels, to bring the same to Jerusalem to the house of our God.

31 ¶ And we departed from the river Ahava on the twelfth day of the first month, to go unto Jerusalem: and the hand of our God was over us, and he delivered us from the hand of any enemy, and of such as lie in wait on the way.

32 And we came to Jerusalem, and remained there three days.

33 And on the fourth day were the silver and the gold and the vessels weighed out in the house of our God into the hand of Meremoth the son of Uriyah the priest; and with him was El'azar the son of Phinehas; and with them was Jozabad the son of Jeshua', and No'adyah the son of Binnui, the Levites;

34 By number and by weight of everything: and all the weight was written down at the same time.

35 ¶ Those that came out of the captivity, the children of the exile, offered burnt-offerings unto the God of Israel, twelve bullocks for all Israel, ninety and six rams, seventy and seven sheep, twelve he-goats for a sin-offering: all as burnt-offerings unto the LORD.

36 And they delivered the king's commands unto the king's lieutenants, and to the governors on this side of the river: and these endowed the people, and the house of God.

CHAPTER IX.

1 ¶ Now when these things were accomplished, the princes approached me, saying, The people of Israel, and the priests, and the Levites, have not separated themselves from the nations of the lands, notwithstanding their abominations, from the Canaanites, the Hittites, the Perizzites, the Jebusites, the

^a Rashi: the *Ketib* הַכֶּתִּיב, which gives the above version; the *Keri*, however, הַכֶּתִּיבִים *nethinim*, the "temple-servants." Ezra could only persuade, not command.

any of those who remained in exile, to return; and no doubt the greater part preferred to stay behind.

^b Rashi. Lit. "an upright way."

'Ammonites, the Moabites, the Egyptians, and the Emorites;

2 For they have taken of their daughters for themselves and for their sons; and the holy seed have mingled themselves with the nations of these lands; and the hand of the princes and rulers hath been the first in this trespass.

3 And when I heard this thing, I rent my garment and my mantle, and I plucked out some of the hair of my head and of my beard, and sat down astounded.

4 And then assembled themselves unto me every one that trembled at the words of the God of Israel, because of the trespass of the exiles: and I sat astounded until the evening sacrifice.

5 And at the evening sacrifice I rose up from my fasting, and while rending^a my garment and my mantle, I knelt down upon my knees, and spread out my hands unto the LORD my God.

6 And I said, O my God, I am ashamed and confounded to lift up my face unto thee, my God! for our iniquities are increased above our head, and our guiltiness is grown up as far as the heavens.

7 From the days of our fathers have we been in a great guiltiness even until this day; and through our iniquities have we been delivered, we, our kings, and our priests, into the hand of the kings of the lands, to the sword, to captivity, and to a spoil, and to the shame of face, as it is this day.

8 And now for a little moment hath grace been extended from the LORD our God, to preserve us a remnant to escape, and to give us a stake^b in his holy place, that our God might enlighten our eyes, and give us a little reviving in our bondage.

9 For we are bondmen: yet in our bondage hath our God not forsaken us, but hath extended unto us kindness before the kings of Persia, to give us a reviving, to exalt the house of our God, and to erect again its ruins, and to give us a fence^c in Judah and in Jerusalem.

10 And now what shall we say, O our

God, after this? for we have forsaken thy commandments,

11 Which thou hast commanded through means of thy servants the prophets, saying, The land, unto which ye go to take possession thereof, is a land defiled through the defilement of the nations of the lands, through their abominations, with which they have filled it from one end to another through their uncleanness.

12 And now your daughters shall ye not give unto their sons, and their daughters shall ye not take for your sons, and ye shall not seek their peace and their welfare unto eternity: in order that ye may be strong, and eat the best of the land, and leave it for an inheritance to your children unto eternity.

13 And after all that is come over us for our evil deeds, and for our great guiltiness, seeing that thou our God hast spared us (punishing us) less than our iniquities (deserved), and hast given us such deliverance as this:

14 Should we again make void thy commandments, and make marriage with these people of abominations? wouldst thou not be angry with us even to make an end of us, so that there would not be any remnant or escape?

15 ¶ O LORD, God of Israel, thou art righteous; for we have been left a remnant that hath escaped, as it is this day: behold, we are before thee in our guiltinesses; for there is no standing^d before thee because of this.

CHAPTER X.

1 ¶ Now when 'Ezra prayed, and when he made his confession, weeping and casting himself down before the house of God, there gathered themselves unto him out of Israel a very large assembly of men and women and children; for the people wept exceedingly much.

2 ¶ Thereupon commenced Shechanyah the son of Jechiel, of the sons of 'Elam, and said unto 'Ezra, We have indeed trespassed against our God, and have brought home strange wives of the nations of the land: yet

^a First, "and with my rent garment and mantle," &c.

^b Lat. "nail," i. e. the nail or stake by which the ends of a tent are fastened to the ground, metaphoric for something not easily removed.

^c As round a sheepfold; i. e. protection.

^d Meaning, it is sure that God's mercy permitted the people to escape total destruction; but this new transgression would cause that the LORD would sweep off those who, notwithstanding the merciful chastisement, could so soon forget again their God.

now there is hope in Israel concerning this thing.

3 And now let us make a covenant with our God to put away all the wives, and such as are born of them, according to the direction of the Lord, and of those that tremble at the commandment of our God; and let it be done according to the law.

4 Arise; for this matter is obligatory upon thee; and we will be with thee: be strong, and do it.

5 ¶ Then arose 'Ezra, and caused the princes of the priests, the Levites, and of all Israel, to swear to do according to this word. And they swore.

6 Then arose 'Ezra from before the house of God, and went into the chamber of Jochanan the son of Elyashib; and he went thither without having eaten bread, or having drunk water; for he was mourning because of the trespass of the exiles.

7 And they made proclamation throughout Judah and Jerusalem unto all the children of the exile, to gather themselves together at Jerusalem;

8 And that whosoever should not come within three days, according to the resolve of the princes and the elders, all his substance should be devoted, and himself separated from the congregation of the exiles.

9 ¶ Then were all the men of Judah and Benjamin gathered together unto Jerusalem within three days: it was in the ninth month, on the twentieth day of the month; and all the people sat in the open place before the house of God, trembling because of this matter, and by reason of the showers of rain.^a

10 And 'Ezra the priest rose up, and said unto them, Ye have acted unfaithfully, and have brought home strange wives, to increase yet more the guiltiness of Israel.

11 Now therefore make confession unto the LORD the God of your fathers, and do his will; and separate yourselves from the nations of the earth, and from the strange wives.

12 Then answered all the assembly and said with a loud voice, So be it: according to thy word it is our duty to do.

13 But the people are many, and it is the

rainy season, and we have not the strength to remain in the street, nor is this a work for one day or for two days; for we are many that have transgressed in this matter.

14 Let however our princes stand forward for all the congregation, and let all those in our cities who have brought home strange wives come at appointed times, and with them the elders of each and every city, and its judges, until the fierce wrath of our God be turned away from us for this whole matter.

15 Only Jonathan the son of 'Assahël and Jachzeyah the son of Thikvah withstood this (proposal):^b and Meshullam and Shabbethai the Levite assisted them.

16 And the children of the exile did so. And then were set apart 'Ezra the priest, (and) certain chiefs of the divisions, for their family divisions, and all of them (designated) by their names; and they sat down on the first day of the tenth month to examine the matter.

17 And they made an end with all, with the men that had brought home strange wives, not before the first day of the first month.

18 ¶ And there were found among the sons of the priests that had brought home strange wives, namely, of the sons of Jeshua' the son of Jozadak, and his brethren: Ma'asseyah, and Eli'ezer, and Jarib, and Gedalyah.

19 And they gave their hand to put away their wives, and being guilty, (they offered) a ram of the flock for their trespass.

20 And of the sons of Immer: Chanani, and Zebadyah.

21 And of the sons of Charim: Ma'asseyah, and Elijah, and Shema'yah, and Jechiël, and 'Uzziyah.

22 And of the sons of Pashchur: Elyo'enai, Ma'asseyah, Ishmael, Nethanel, Jozabad, and El'assah.

23 Also of the Levites: Jozabad, and Shim'i, and Kelayah, the same is Kelita, Pethachyah, Judah, and Eli'ezer.

24 And of the singers, Elyashib; and of the gate-keepers, Shallum, and Telem, and Uri.

25 And of Israel: Of the sons of Par'osh,

^a Lit. "rains;" the ninth month, Kislev, (December,) is the rainy season in Palestine.

^b Rashi. Lit. "they stood upon this," i. e. insisted on the original proposition. Philippon, "And—insisted on."

NEHEMIAH I.

Ranayah, and Yizziyah, and Malkiyah, and Miyamin, and El'azar, and Malkiyah, and Benayah.

26 And of the sons of 'Elam: Matthanayah, Zecharyah, and Jechi'el, and 'Abdi, and Jeremoth, and Eliyah.

27 And of the sons of Zatthu: Elyo'enai, Elyashib, Matthanayah, and Jeremoth, and Zabad, and 'Aziza.

28 And of the sons of Bebai: Jehochanan, Chananyah, Zabbai, and 'Athlai.

29 And of the sons of Bani: Meshullam, Malluch, and 'Adayah, Jashub, and She'ul, and Ramoth.

30 And of the sons of Pachath-mo'ab: 'Adna, and Kelal, Benayah, Ma'asseyah, Matthanayah, Bezalel, and Binnui, and Menasseh.

31 And of the sons of Charim: Eli'ezer, Yishiyah, Malkiyah, Shema'yah, Shim'on,

32 Benjamin, Malluch, and Shemaryah.

33 Of the sons of Chashum: Matthenai, Matthathah, Zabad, Eliphelet, Jeremai, Menasseh, and Shim'i.

34 Of the sons of Bani: Ma'adai, 'Amram, and U'el,

35 Benayah, Bedeyah, Keluhu,

36 Vanyah, Meremoth, Elyashib,

37 Matthanayah, Matthenai, and Ja'assai,

38 And Bani, and Binnui, and Shim'i,

39 And Shelemiyah, and Nathan, and Adayah,

40 Machnadbai, Shashai, Sharai,

41 'Asar'el, and Shelemiyahu, Shemaryah,

42 Shallum, Amaryah, and Joseph.

43 Of the sons of 'Nebo: Je'iel, Matthithiyah, Zabad, Zebina, Jaddai, and Jo'el, Bena-yah.

44 All these had taken strange wives; and some of them had wives by whom they had children.

THE BOOK OF NEHEMIAH,

ספר נחמיה.

CHAPTER I.

1 ¶ THE words of Nehemiah^a the son of Chachalyah. And it came to pass in the month Kislev, in the twentieth year, as I was in Shushan the capital,

2 That there came Chanani, one of my brethren^b himself with certain men of Judah: and I asked them concerning the Jews that had escaped, who were left of the captivity, and concerning Jerusalem.

3 And they said unto me, The remnant that are left of the captivity there in the province are in great misery and in disgrace; and the wall of Jerusalem is broken down, and her gates are burnt with fire.

4 And it came to pass, when I heard these words, that I sat down and wept, and mourn-

ed some days, and I was fasting, and praying before the God of heaven.

5 And I said, I beseech thee, O LORD the God of heaven, the great and terrible God, that keepeth the covenant and kindness for those that love him and for those that keep his commandments:

6 Let thy ear now be attentive, and thy eyes be open, I entreat thee, to hearken unto the prayer of thy servant, which I am praying this day before thee, by day and by night, in behalf of the children of Israel thy servants, and (as) I confess for the sins of the children of Israel, (with) which we have sinned against thee: yea, I also and my father's house have sinned.

7 We have dealt very corruptly toward thee; and we have not kept the command-

^a Heb. *Nehemyah*. According to Zanz, his first journey to Palestine took place in the year of the world 3541 or 14 years after Ezra's expedition.

^b Rashi, "one of my friends;" the word "brother" being often used in this sense, as also to denote any near relative.